

Chapter

Prime Minister and Council of Ministers

1. The Council of Ministers headed by the Prime Minister aids and advises the President. In this context, answer the following questions:

(i) Mention any three points to distinguish between the Council of Ministers and the Cabinet.

(ii) Who appoints the Cabinet Ministers? Mention any two administrative powers of the Cabinet.

(iii) The President is the nominal head of the Indian Union. Mention any four functions of the Prime Minister with reference to the President.

MAIN 2024

2. Does the resignation of the Prime Minister mean the resignation of the whole Cabinet ?

SQP 2023

3. What do the Prime Minister and other Ministers affirm under :

(a) the Oath of Office.

(b) the Oath of Secrecy.

SQP 2023

4. The junior category of ministers who assist senior ministers:

(a) Cabinet Ministers

(b) Ministers of State

(c) Deputy Ministers

(d) Council of Ministers

MAIN 2023

5. State any two legislative powers of the Cabinet.

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6. A large number of people are killed in a major rail accident. What happens if the Railway Minister resigns from the post on moral grounds?

MAIN 2023

7. The President's Special Address to Parliament is prepared by

- (a) The Prime Minister
- (b) The Vice President
- (c) The Cabinet
- (d) The Speaker of the Lok Sabha

SQP 2022

8. What role does the Prime Minister play as the Leader of the Nation ?

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Solution

1.

Ans:

(i) Three points of distinction between the Council of Ministers and the Cabinet:

1. **Size:** The Council of Ministers includes all categories of ministers— Cabinet Ministers, Ministers of State and Deputy Ministers—whereas the Cabinet consists only of senior Cabinet Ministers.
2. **Meetings:** The Cabinet meets frequently to take important decisions, while the Council of Ministers rarely meets as a whole.
3. **Decision-making:** The Cabinet formulates major policies and decisions, while the Council of Ministers implements these decisions at different levels.

(ii) Who appoints the Cabinet Ministers?

The President appoints the Cabinet Ministers on the advice of the Prime Minister.

Two administrative powers of the Cabinet:

1. **Policy formulation:** The Cabinet frames national policies and takes decisions on important legislative matters.
2. **Implementation of laws:** The Cabinet ensures that laws passed by Parliament are properly implemented.

(iii) Four functions of the Prime Minister with reference to the President:

1. **Chief advisor:** The Prime Minister advises the President on all matters of governance.
2. **Link between President and Cabinet:** The Prime Minister acts as the main channel of communication between the President and the Council of Ministers.
3. **Cabinet formation:** The Prime Minister recommends the appointment of ministers and allocates portfolios.

4. Keeping the President informed: The Prime Minister keeps the President informed about important decisions and policies of the government.

2.

Ans: Yes, the resignation of the Prime Minister results in the resignation of the entire Cabinet.

3.

Ans:

(a) Oath of Office:

The Prime Minister and other Ministers affirm:

- (i) Loyalty to the Constitution of India.
- (ii) Faithful and honest discharge of their duties.
- (iii) Upholding the sovereignty and integrity of India.

(b) Oath of Secrecy:

They pledge not to disclose any official information or Cabinet discussions, except as required by law.

4.

Ans: (b) Ministers of State

Explanation:

Ministers of State belong to the junior category of ministers. They assist Cabinet Ministers in their work and may be given independent charge of specific departments or work under the guidance of senior ministers.

5.

Ans: Any two legislative powers of the Cabinet are:

1. Drafting of Bills: The Cabinet prepares and introduces most of the Bills in Parliament in accordance with government policies.

2. Control over Legislative Agenda: The Cabinet decides which Bills will be introduced in Parliament and fixes their priority for discussion and passage.

6.

Ans: If the Railway Minister resigns on moral grounds after a major rail accident, **only the Railway Minister steps down**. The resignation does **not** require the entire Cabinet to resign, as each minister is individually responsible for their own department.

7.

Ans: (c) The Cabinet.

Explanation:

The President's Special Address to Parliament is prepared by the Cabinet. Although the President delivers the address, its content reflects the policies and programme of the government, which are formulated by the Cabinet.

8.

Ans: As the Leader of the Nation, the Prime Minister represents the country at home and abroad. He/she announces major national policies, leads the government, and speaks on behalf of the nation in international affairs. The Prime Minister provides leadership to the people and guides the country in times of peace and crisis, reflecting the voice and will of the nation.